sixty elephants and the offer of a bride for Khusrau. But these offers were understood by Akbar for what they were—delaying tactics while the garrison wore down the Mughal forces by attrition. Instead, Akbar countered with a diplomatic move, summoning an officer from Agra who was also the grandson of Raja Ali Khan. In the presence of this member of the Khandesh royal family, a number of the Deccani officers capitulated.

The resistance of Asirgarh, however, stuttered wearily along. As the neighbouring forts fell, Ahmadnagar and Maligarh amongst others, survivors crowded into Asirgarh, until it was crammed with about 34,000 people. The overstretched resources of the fort began to crumble and eventually led to an epidemic within the fort, eroding even further the morale of the defending garrison. Asirgarh Fort was already packed with royal prisoners, for it was the custom to imprison all other pretenders to the throne apart from the reigning monarch, and seven princes of the Faruqui dynasty were imprisoned at the time. Bribery was resorted to on both sides, to undermine the strength of the resistance, and to convince vacillating parties to desert. By this stage of empire formation, diplomacy, bribery, and intimidation were commonly resorted to because the Mughal military capability was so formidable that those ranged against it often preferred to avoid war. Bahadur Shah was a notable exception.

At one point, Akbar decided to use siege guns, but very few had been brought along with the Mughal army since it had not been thought likely that Bahadur Shah would refuse to submit. The details of the final fall of Asirgarh remain obscure, as there were contradictory reports written by the Jesuits and the Muslim chroniclers. Bahadur Shah, demoralized by the conditions within the fort and uncertain of the loyalty of his officers, finally submitted to Akbar in December 1600 and agreed to appear before him, accompanied by the Ethiopian officer, Muqarrib Khan. Akbar accepted this surrender and effectively placed Bahadur Shah under arrest, and then asked him to write a letter to the garrison, which was still holding out under the leadership of Muqarrib Khan’s father, Yaqut Khan. But Yaqut Khan, valorous till the end, was furious with his son for having brought such a letter to the fort. Unable to bear the humiliation of his father’s disappointment, Muqarrib Khan committed suicide. The elderly Yaqut Khan then tried to hustle one of the Faruqui princes in the fort into taking up the leadership of Asirgarh but with the tents of the mighty Mughal travelling camp snapping in the wind on the scorched battlefield outside the fort, the